

Yuya Kato Meeting July 1

Yuya Kato is actually a very strategic person for you to meet. Unlike Yuko Koshiba, who is likely to think in terms of **philanthropic strategy and ecosystem building**, someone from the **Japan Social Innovation and Investment Foundation (SIIF)** is likely to think in terms of **how innovative projects become investable and legally structured**.

Since your objective is **pro bono legal support**, I would avoid making that the opening topic. Instead, first establish that your project is the kind of initiative SIIF exists to encourage.

1. How do projects like Mitsue fit into SIIF's view of impact investing? ★ ★ ★ ★ ★

Start with a broad question:

"I've been working on the Mitsue Project, which combines forest restoration, renewable energy, AI infrastructure and regional revitalization. I'm curious—where would SIIF place a project like this within the impact investing landscape?"

This invites him to classify your project rather than defend it.

2. Structuring the organization ★ ★ ★ ★ ★

One of the biggest questions for Mitsue is organizational structure.

Ask: "We're exploring different legal and governance structures. From your experience, what structure gives projects like this the greatest flexibility to attract both philanthropic and commercial capital?"

Possible areas he'll mention: nonprofit · public-interest corporation · foundation · general incorporated association · social enterprise · hybrid structures

3. Public-interest certification (公益認定) ★ ★ ★ ★ ★

Since you've already mentioned this to Yuko:

"We're also exploring a path toward 公益認定. In your experience, what are the biggest mistakes organizations make before they begin that process?"

4. Blended finance ★ ★ ★ ★ ★

Since this is literally the conference topic:

"Do you think Japan is ready for projects that intentionally combine grants, philanthropy, concessionary capital and commercial investment from the beginning?"

5. Legal barriers ★ ★ ★ ★ ★

Now you're getting closer to your actual need.

Ask: "From your perspective, what legal issues tend to slow innovative regional projects the most?"

This naturally leads toward legal support.

6. Open source and public benefit ★ ★ ★ ★ ★

This is something unique about Mitsue.

You could ask: "Much of what we're developing is intended to be open source so other rural communities can replicate it. Do you think that strengthens the public-benefit case?"

That's a genuinely interesting legal and governance question.

7. Governance ★ ★ ★ ★ ★

Since SIIF cares about governance:

"What governance characteristics make you immediately trust a new social-impact project?"

That question alone can generate a 15-minute conversation.

8. Environmental assets ★ ★ ★ ★ ★

This is unique. Ask: "Have you seen projects that combine forest restoration with digital infrastructure in a way that investors found compelling?"

I suspect the answer will be "not many."

9. When to involve lawyers ★ ★ ★ ★ ★

This is where you naturally transition. Instead of saying: "Can you help us?"

Ask: "At what stage do you normally recommend projects start working with lawyers? We've reached the point where we're beginning to think seriously about governance, agreements and future investment."

Now you're talking about timing rather than asking for free work.

10. The pro bono question

Only after you've had a good conversation. Something like:

"One challenge for early-stage public-interest projects is that legal costs arrive long before funding does. Are you aware of any firms or programs in Japan that provide pro bono or reduced-fee legal support for projects with a clear public-benefit mission?"

Notice that you're not asking him to provide legal services. You're asking about the ecosystem. If he knows of a program—or thinks your project is a good fit—he may volunteer an introduction.

One question I'd definitely ask

If I could ask only one question, it would be:

"Looking at the Mitsue Project, what would you strengthen first before presenting it to impact investors or philanthropic partners?"

That's an invitation for constructive advice, and it signals that you're interested in building a stronger project rather than simply seeking funding or legal assistance.

If the conversation goes exceptionally well

You might end with:

"I'd really appreciate staying in touch. As the project develops, there may be opportunities where a legal or governance perspective would make a significant difference, and I'd value your thoughts."

That leaves the door open for future collaboration without putting him on the spot.

One small note: you mentioned Yuya Kato is "from SIIF." Before the event, it's worth confirming his current role and responsibilities, as people in Japan's impact investing ecosystem sometimes move between organizations or serve in multiple capacities. Knowing exactly what he currently works on will help you tailor these questions even more precisely.